600 seconds of elegant flight washed off our entire fatigue in an instant. What a wonderful culmination of our years of labour. I wrote in my diary that night:

Do not look at Agni
as an entity directed upward
to deter the ominous
or exhibit your might.
It is fire
in the heart of an Indian.
Do not even give it
the form of a missile
as it clings to the
burning pride of this nation
and thus is bright.

Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi cal ed the Agni launch “a major achievement in our continuing efforts to safeguard our independence and security by self-reliant means. The technology demonstration through Agni is a reflection of our commitment to the indigenous development of advanced technologies for the nation’s defence.” “The country is proud of your efforts,” he told me. President Venkataraman saw in the Agni success the fulfilment of his dream. He